

Episode 175: *Mawaru Penguindrum* Colour Design Notes Part 2

I'm in Kyushu. Research and location hunting for a certain new work. Nagasaki, Kumamoto, and today Kagoshima. So this manuscript is being finished at a certain location in front of Kagoshima Station while getting coffee refills.

For us Tokyo people, Kyushu has a somewhat tropical image, but unlike Okinawa, Kyushu's latitude isn't actually that different from Tokyo. So well, it's normally cold. We were suddenly hit by snow at Aso! (laugh)

A complete silver world! The scenery was already Hokkaido (laugh).

Yesterday's weather was somewhat disappointing like that, but this morning in Kagoshima is clear with good weather forecast. Today's another full day of hard research work.

Anyway.

Bank scene "Crystal World" actually started work after the new year.

What took time first was Himari's queen outfit, commonly called "Princess of Crystal" costume. Character concepts themselves were received from Hoshino Lily-san, and the famous "penguin hat" was approved early with animation progressing, but the problem was this "queen" outfit's colours.

Standing pose wearing that "penguin hat." The image of black base with clear red was common to Director Ikuhara and me, but when actually colouring along those lines, wait? It resembles something (sweat).

"Ah, Doronjo-sama! (explosion)"

From there, endless worry spiral (laugh). Adding highlight animation to suits and skirts, devising muffler colours and paint divisions. But with black and red as base, that image inevitably remains. So ultimately "well, fine" (laugh).

We added fluffy volume feeling by making all frilly designs from sleeves and skirts front to back into colour tracing finishing (色トレス仕上げ), somehow pulling it together.

Bank scenes are hybrids of normal animation cuts and 3D. Parts where characters like "Princess" appear and act are animation, but "baskets" containing teddy bears and teddy bears (white ones) in several cuts are 3DCG. Teddy bears were handled by Nakamura Akiko-san, "rocket," "pencil sharpener," and "basket" designs by Shibata Katsunori-kun. I considered colours for designs created in animation (basic colour concepts for both black and white teddy bears from Akiko-san) for colouring. Based on that, Machida Masaya-san handled 3D modelling and movement. I added further colour corrections to those demos.

From the director, there was only an image meeting of "dark space, then after teddy bears and Princess appear, space becomes whitish space" - so I'd create specific colour samples first.

Passing ticket gates, rushing through space(?) to see the workplace nickname "Himari's star." Rockets launching from this, racing through dark space, I thought should be whitish. Somewhat Apollo spacecraft image.

"Himari's star" - rotating frame is animation, central light rays are materials from art staff. Stars flying toward the front have only movement created in animation.

"Pencil sharpeners" and "baskets" after breaking through dark space into pure white space, I thought should go with clear pink. Pink + metallic gimmick parts are gold, with emerald green allocated to glass accordingly. Then white teddy bears burst out boom! bang! from within.

First, 3D for these "pencil sharpeners" and "baskets" took shape. Then other cuts, overall work.

After teddy bear appearances, I wanted to firmly show colours for Princess and "dialogue" partner characters (#1: Kanba & Shoma). So I thought we could go with basic "normal" colour direction as-is, but background space decisions were delayed, so I was uncertain about final approaches until the end.

Background space would use "gear"-shaped things and "monogram icons" and "route maps" created by Osakabe-san to make infinite image space, but assembly was to be requested from photography staff. Since I would ultimately do colour adjustment and decisions for completed space, we were waiting for photography staff.

Bank scenes and Episode 1 excluding opening and ending were almost completed in early May. Bank scenes had delayed animation, with full work becoming May and June. Bank scene photography was requested from Graphinica, and the first photography meeting was held amazingly one month before broadcast - quite a tightrope walk. Director, Akiko-san, Yamasaki-san, and I visited Graphinica for meetings. Trying to convey images somehow, the director stood up with gestures for quite a long meeting.

Several days after meetings, additional 3D-related parts began coming up from Graphinica's 3D team. "Stairs" from teddy bear crotch to crotch, etc. I coloured rough materials and returned them to the 3D team. These were also pink-based naturally. Rockets worked on in animation also finished colouring, passing everything to photography staff. Putting materials into photography like this, we waited for photography completion.

Two weeks after the first meeting, bank scene rushes came up and we returned to Graphinica. The completed rushes shown completely amazed the director and all of us!

Magnificent! Bank scenes were assembled and created at scales many times what we'd envisioned, finished into glittering beautiful footage.

Movement dummy materials had seven-coloured starlight and afterimages applied, rocket-rushing space had art material snow and ice crystals. And crystal space had Osakabe-san's icons and route maps moving beautifully. Magnificent screens with no room for me to adjust colour tone. An explosion of Graphinica's team power and Photography Director Ogiwara Takeo's sensibility.

We requested additional instructions and corrections for just a few points, with recheck several days later. On the way back in the elevator, Director Ikuhara's momentarily happy smile saying "well, this might work. It might be a hit (laugh)" was impressive.

However, we still had big challenges remaining. Yes, the opening and ending problems remained.

(12.01.17)